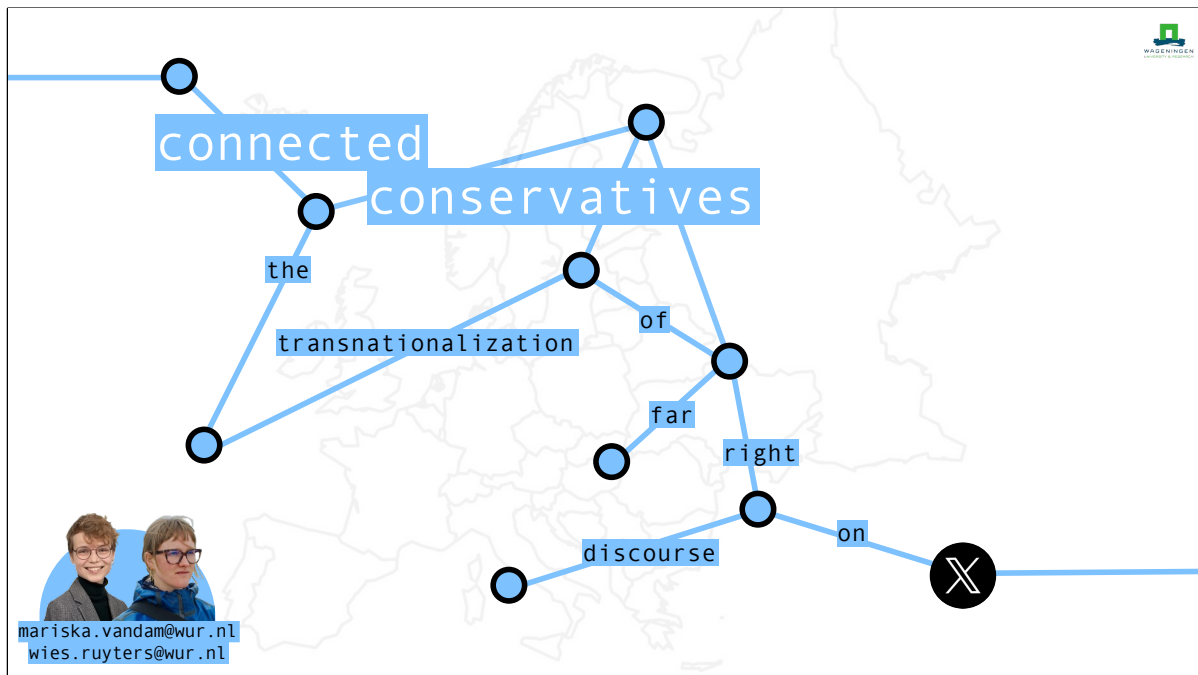
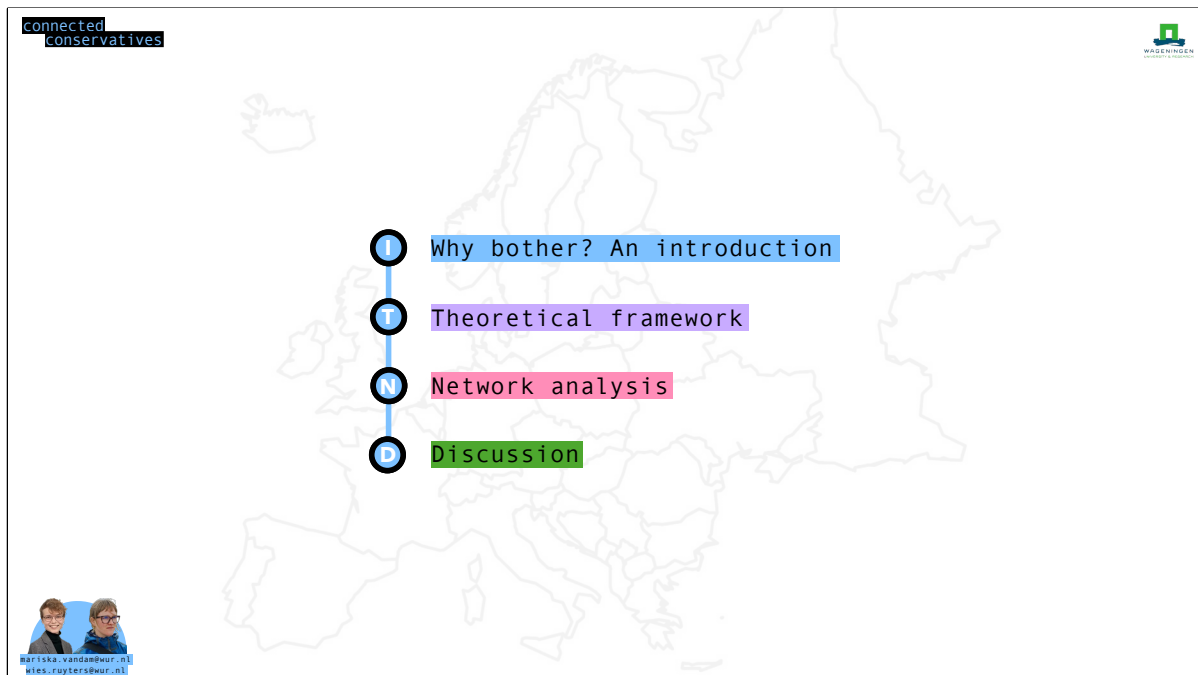




Welcome to today's presentation of the project of my dear colleague Mariska and myself called "Connected Conservatives: the transnationalization of far right discourse on X.com". This presentation was given at the European Consortium for Political Research general conference, better known as ECPR party.



This presentation walks you through four pillars in this project; the introduction, the theoretical framework, the analysis, and a discussion. This project is in a pretty early stage still, so we welcome any kind of feedback. Let's begin.

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Social movement perspective on the “far right”

The ‘far right’ as **umbrella** term (Mudde 2019; Pirro 2023)

Blurry boundaries in terms of *ideologies, organization, and collective action mobilization*

The far-right is growing in popularity worldwide, and increasingly taking part in government and policymaking.

The far right is increasingly referred to as an umbrella, that groups radical right, that is antiliberal, and extreme right, that is antidemocratic, parties together. We agree that this makes sense, as there is a lot of overlap between these party families. The far right’s ideological core is characterized by nativism, authoritarianism, and populism, for which it endangers the institutionalized values in a liberal democracy.

But the far right is not only shaped by political actors. Several scholars argue that ideologies, organizations and collective action mobilization are indispensable co-creators of the far right’s growth that is witnessed across the globe.

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WAGeningen

Transnationalization: enabled by social media

Social media important **enabler** (Lavizzari and Siročić 2023; Törnberg and Nissen 2023)

"Anti-nationalist **Europeans**" versus "Pro-European **Nativists**" (Caiani and Weisskircher, 2022)

And this all with a starring role for social media. The superfluous traffic of far right communication on these platforms reaches far beyond national borders, helped by the built-in translation functions that several of them offer today.

But if the ideological core of the far right – nativist, authoritarian and populist – has a strong national focus, isn't it quite paradoxical that we study its transnationalization?

Interestingly: no. Caiani and Weisskircher show that there is a notable shift from EU opposition to EU reform. In their 2022 paper, they conceptualize this by studying the far-right either as Anti-nationalist European versus Pro-European nativist.

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Research Question:

How do **European far right actors** connect transnationally on X?

👥 *What type of connections exist between different actor types?*

🌐 *To what extent are these connections transnational?*

Several scientific papers have addressed far right transnationalization, and it became a research area on its own. But most of them either focus on a specific type of actor, sometimes within a country. Given the blurry boundaries of far right actors, we therefore wondered whether we can map the most important drivers of far right transnationalization – and whether those cross-actor, cross-country connections are transnational at all. We study this on X, as the takeover by billionaire Elon Musk is argued to have boosted far right content through algorithmic curation.

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Social movement perspective on the far right

Ideologies: *radical* (anti-liberal) + *extreme* (anti-democratic)

Organization: '*movement party*' (Minkenberg 2019)

Collective action mobilization: '*laundering*' (Klinger et al. 2023)

As mentioned in the introduction, we approach “the” far right an ideological melt between radical and extreme right.

Further, we take a social movement perspective and do not pre-select actors to include. We think this is important because of a term that was coined by Klinger in 2023: “laundering”. We know laundering more from moneylaundering, etc, and it metaphorically relates to cleaning something that is “wrong”. In this context, that is particularly relevant. Far right parties face – and rightfully so – an increased journalistic interest because of their antidemocratic and antiliberal ideologies. Journalists uncovered several channels within these organizations where neonazi, racist, and fascist discourse circulated freely. With the blurring boundaries of political actors, social movement actors, and alternative media actors, the origins of ideas becomes harder to trace. Klinger found that the extreme-right AfD basically copied a campaign from neonazi activist Martin Sellner, he who is being “cancelled” as too extreme.

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Transnationalization of the far right

Network: *transnationalization* (Keşkekci 2024; Nissen 2022) or *localization* (Lavizzari and Siročić 2023)

Identity frames: e.g., *ethnopluralism* (Rueda 2021; Ahmed and Pisoiu 2021; Volk 2019)

Protest events: remain relatively rare (Caiani 2025a)

When we speak of far right transnationalization, we mean the transcending of far right discourse over borders and across nations, with our focus being on the European continent. The transnationalization of the far right is no new phenomenon, but it has become increasingly relevant. Here, the idea of white superiority used to have a racial base, with the white race being superior to non-white races. Yet, with the introduction of ethnopluralism, coined by Alain de Benoist, the racial argument has been complemented with, or sometimes replaced by a cultural argument, with western cultures being superior to non-western cultures. Note that such a shift offers transnational actors legitimacy to be both nativist and transnationally oriented, as it is not only their national culture, but also their European roots they fight for. Last, several scholars studied transnational far right protests, but no significant trend was found – rather, far-right protests remained nativist-oriented.

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alternative and social media

Discursive opportunity structure (esp. since Twitter became X) (Magalhães et al. 2026)

'RNS' are **transnational actors** too (Heft et al. 2021)

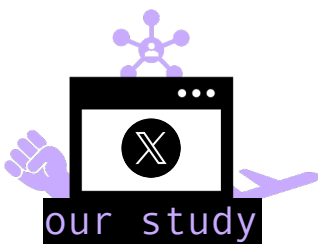
Social media is a textbook example of an emerging phenomenon that facilitates precisely what we want to study: cross-actor and cross-country online discourse. It's almost a trivial choice to collect data from given our ambitions with this project. But there is one social media platform that became even more important for our far-right friends, and that is, as we all know, X.com (former Twitter). X.com is argued to algorithmically favor far-right content and actors, including posts from its owner himself: Elon Musk. Musks' involvement with far-right campaigns, such as him calling into an AfD party congress or his active role within the MAGA movement should not be mistaken as sporadic – to us, it exemplifies the blurring boundaries of roles and actors in politics.

Last, Right Wing Networking Sites (abbreviated RNS) were found to be transnational far right actors too, linking different ideas together and creating an ecosystem within which an ideology can spread.

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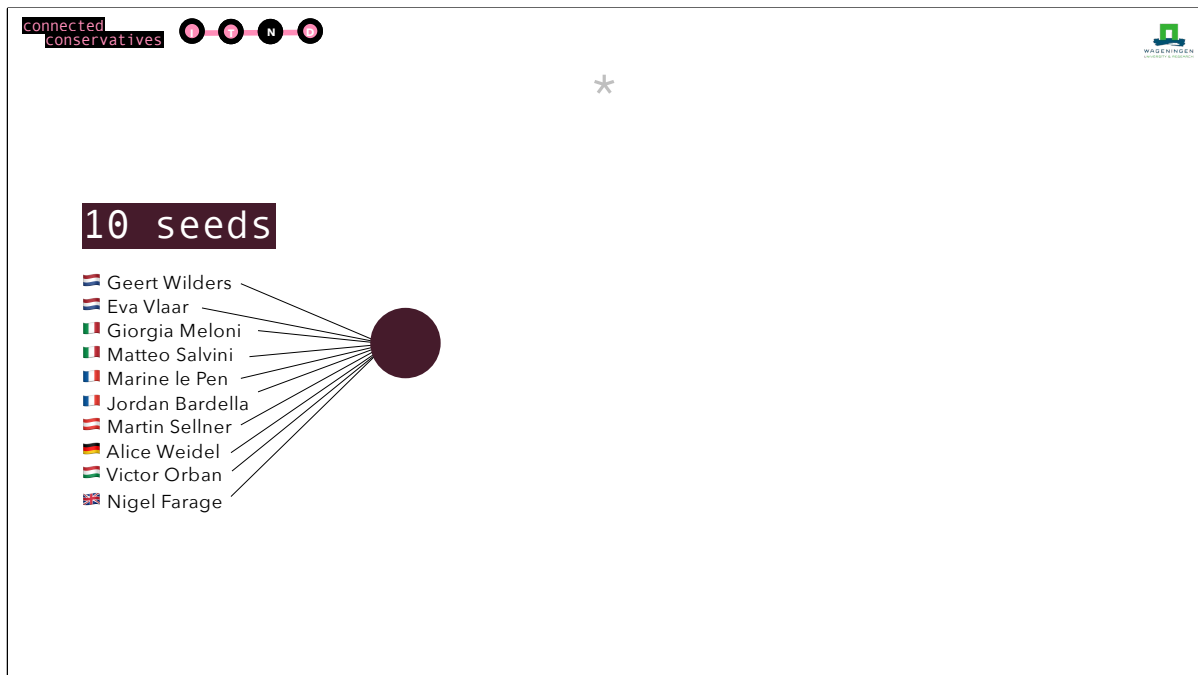
our study

Bottom-up* network construction

Cross-cutting, data-driven **comparison** of national and transnational dynamics

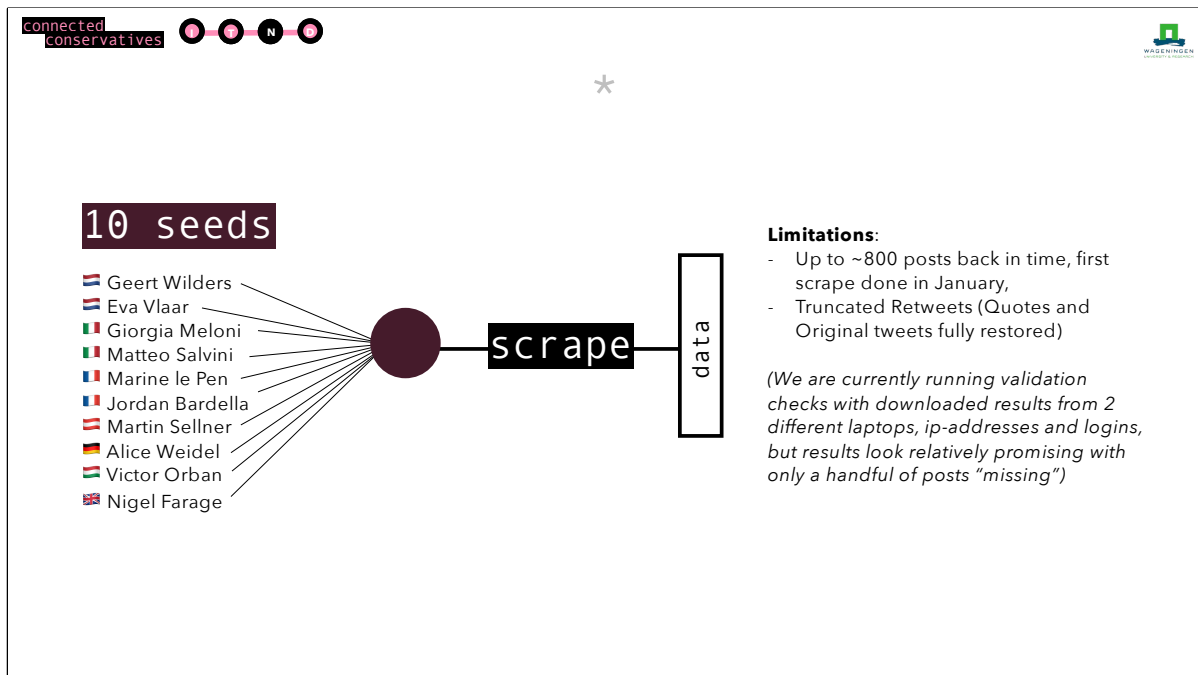
Potentially followed by a qualitative **framing analysis** of transnational posts

So, summing up, we build upon a theoretical framework that encompasses far right transnationalization from a social movement perspective on social media. We contribute to this literature with a new approach, that builds this network bottom up (to be continued), that is without upfront pre-selection of actors, weigh national and transnational dynamics, and potentially identify which actors are key in the transnationalization of far right on X and do a qualitative framing analysis to close it fully. A cherry on the a far right pie, maybe, we'll see.

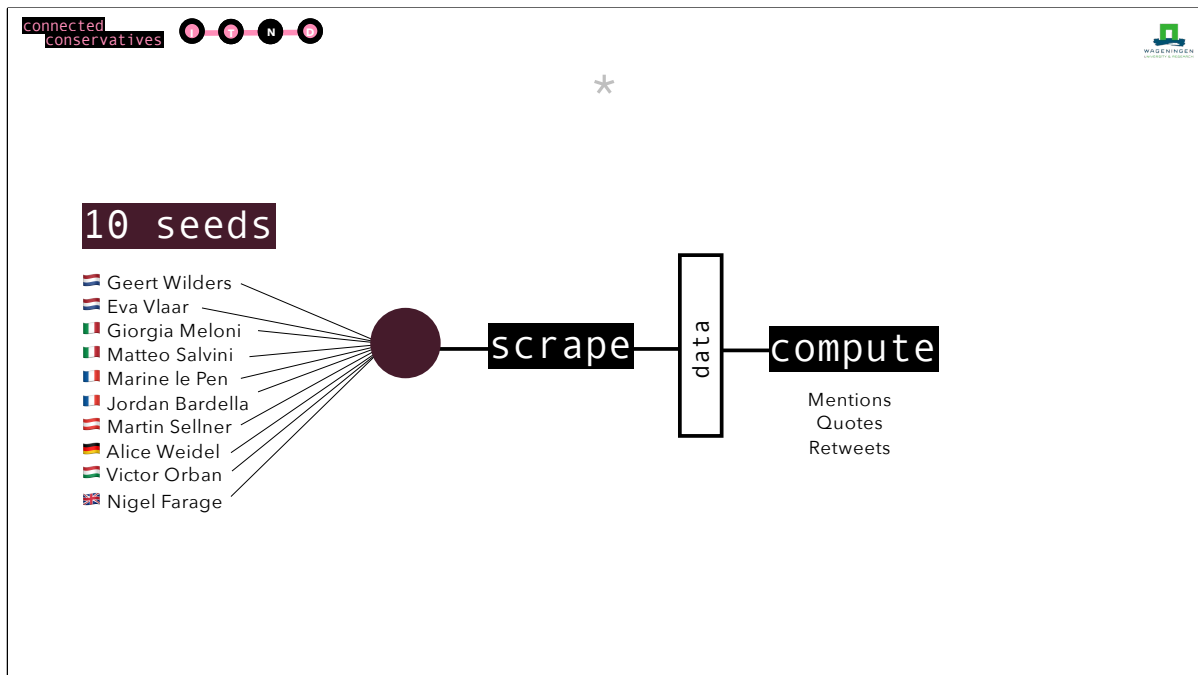


Now let's talk about our data collection preceding the network analysis. Let's see what that asterix means.

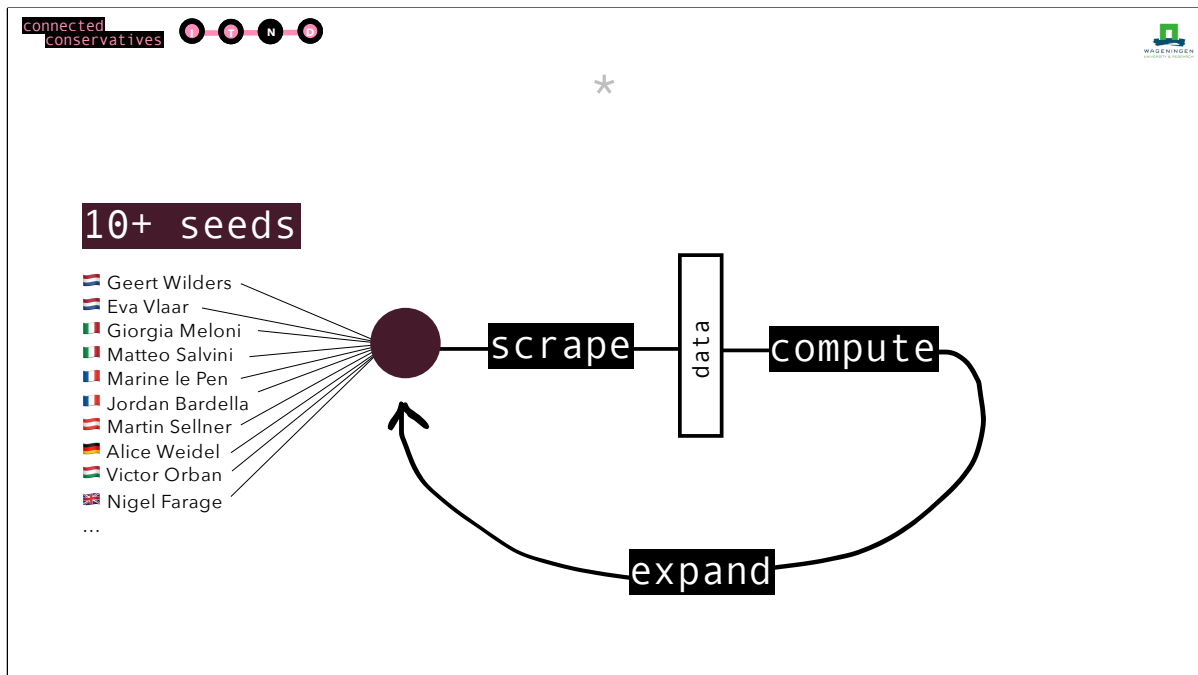
We started with 10 seeds that we deemed crucial in the network of far-right transnationalization – predominantly political (!!)



We found a back door to X.com data, with twikit in python, with which we could scrape, per seed account, up to ~800 posts from today into the past. All data and metadata, like engagement, is there. The only missing data is retweet truncation.

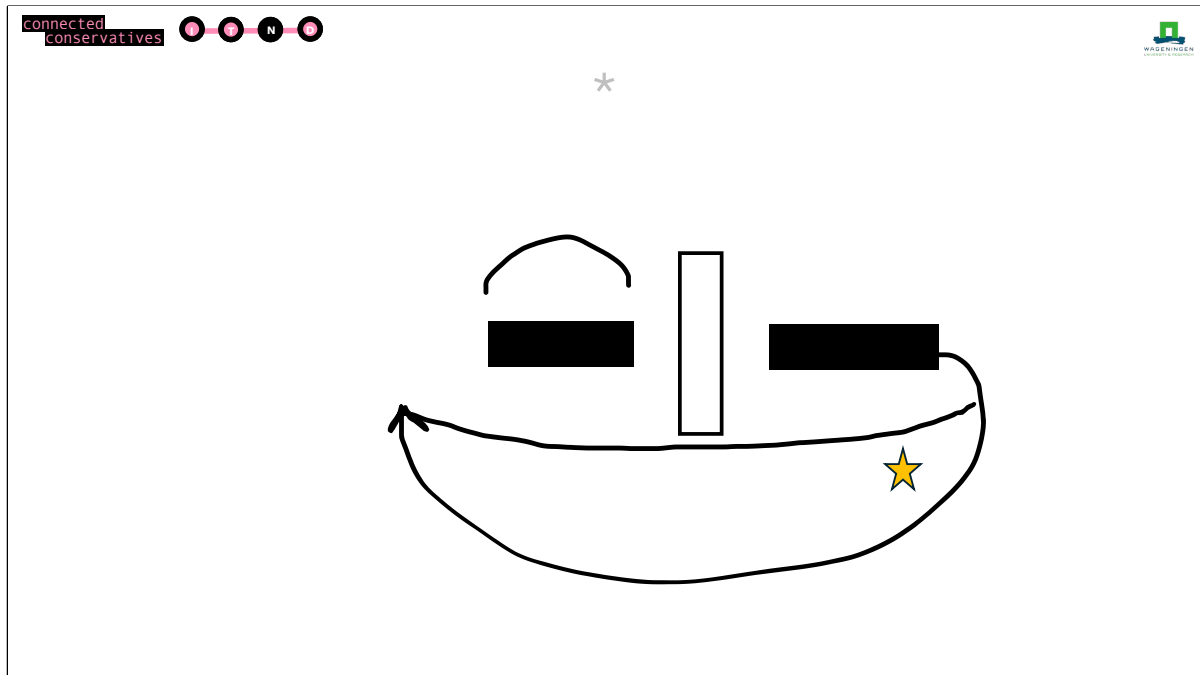


With this collection, we compute the interactions that the actors have over time. Mentions, quotes and retweets count up equally

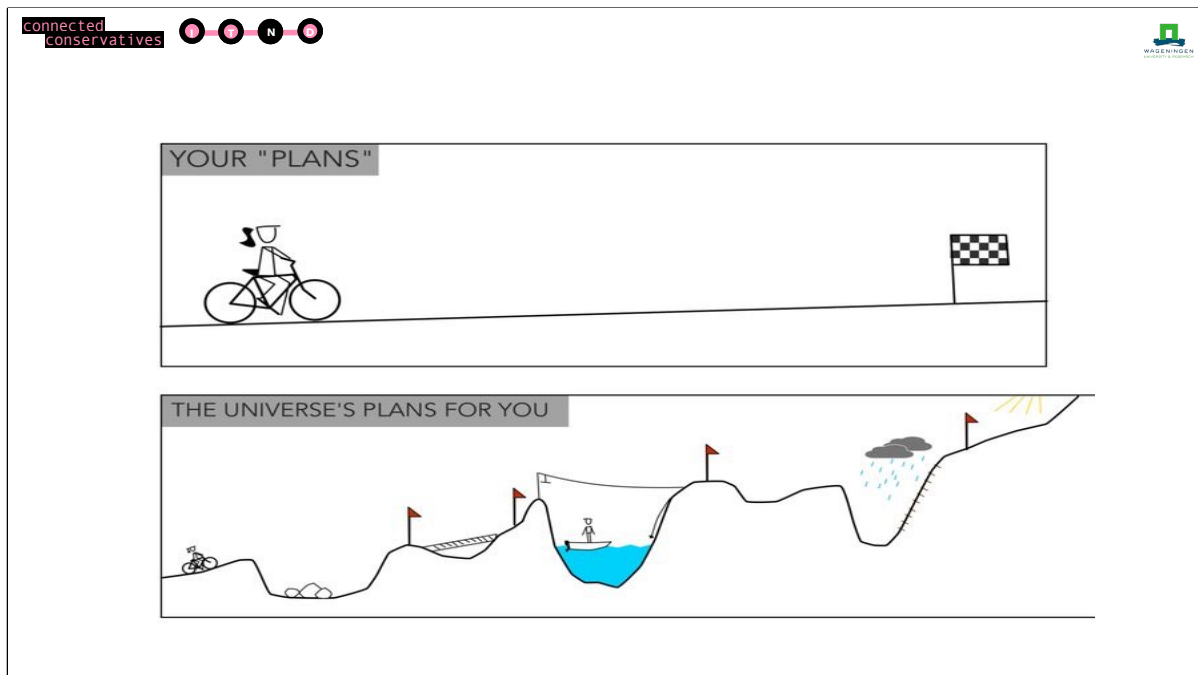


Of the accounts that were frequently interacted with over the scraped data, we check whether an account was:

- An identifiable actor (i.e. not anonymous, not an official party/institution, not a media outlet account)
- European
- Far-right



Sounds legit, we thought



Well it was very naïve, and retrospectively also not really what we should have expected based on the literature of far-right transnationalization in Europe nor twitter/X.com far-right network analyses

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National networks are, almost always, **stronger**
(PiS Poland, we're looking at you 🙄)

Many, many, many, many, many **media accounts** are quoted/tagged
(instrumental use: making racist ideas appear legitimate)

Far right's main occupation seems to **mock the elite**
(we are looking for in-group loyalty, not out-group hatred)

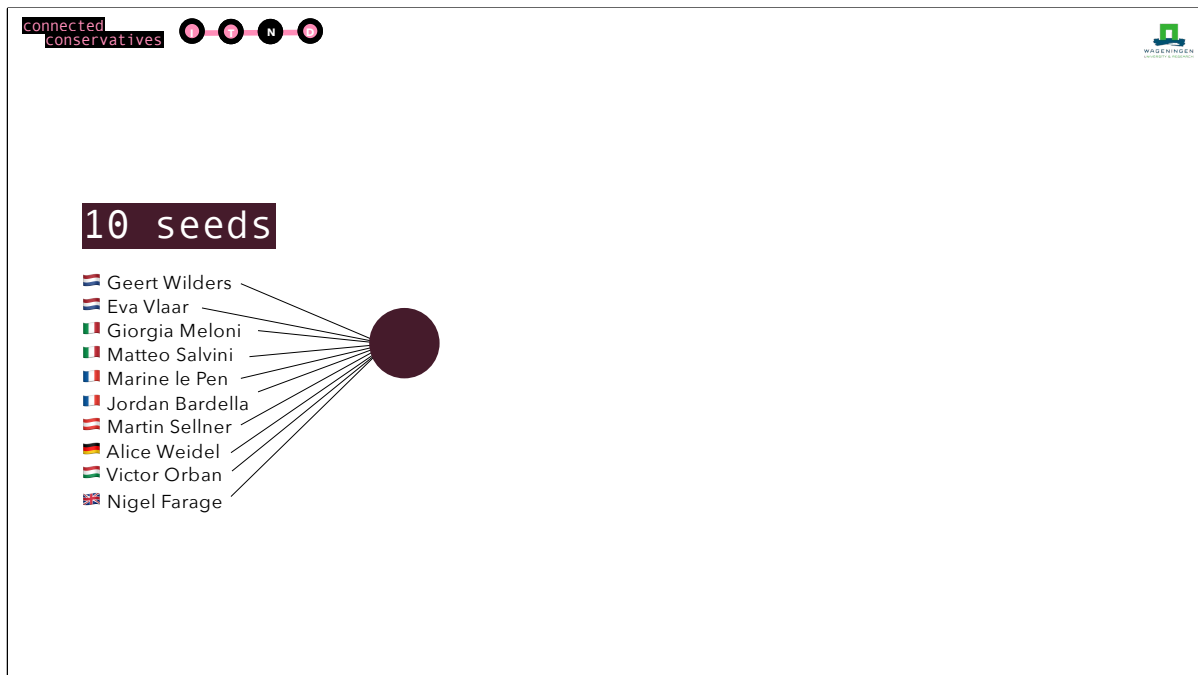
Not all countries are on X, **not all party leaders** are on X
(and who knows all far right social movement actors by heart anyway?)

...Because as soon as we let Poles enter the network, shit hit the fan as they completely took over the network density.

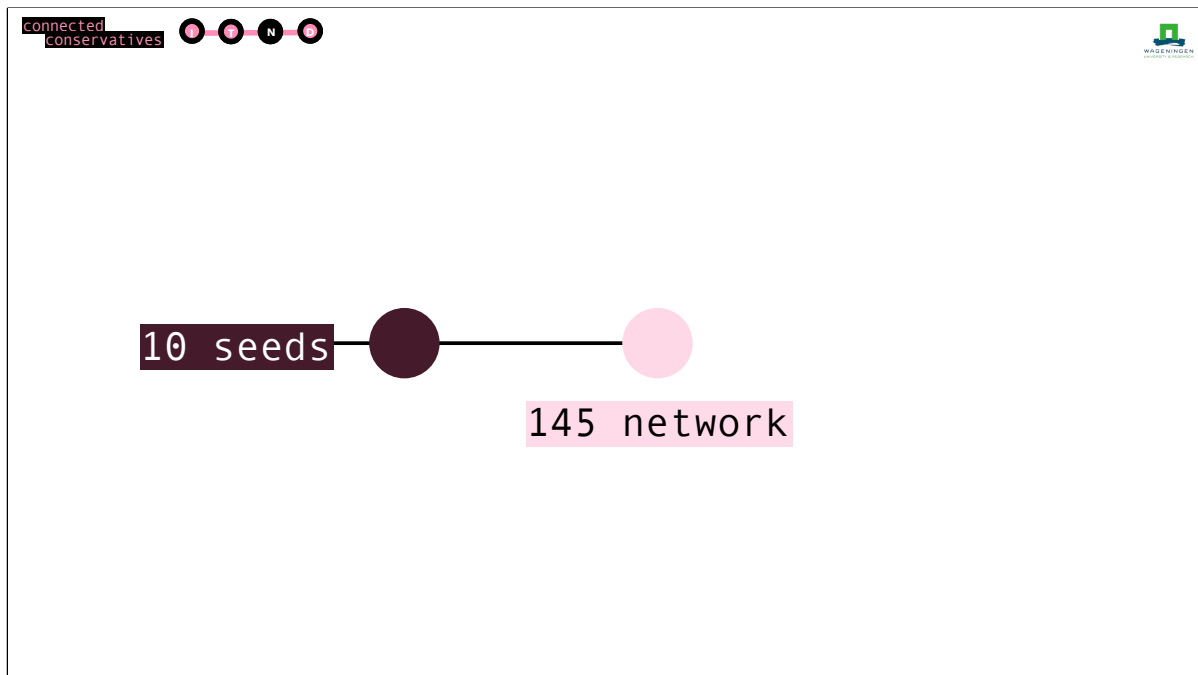
Further, we found that media accounts were very instrumental in the generation of far-right argumentation – an opportunity for us to explore in another paper, as it says something about perceived legitimacy of argumentation, as well as online/offline dynamics through digital reports.

There were, as expected also many interactions with the establishment, sometimes in a populist anti-elite way

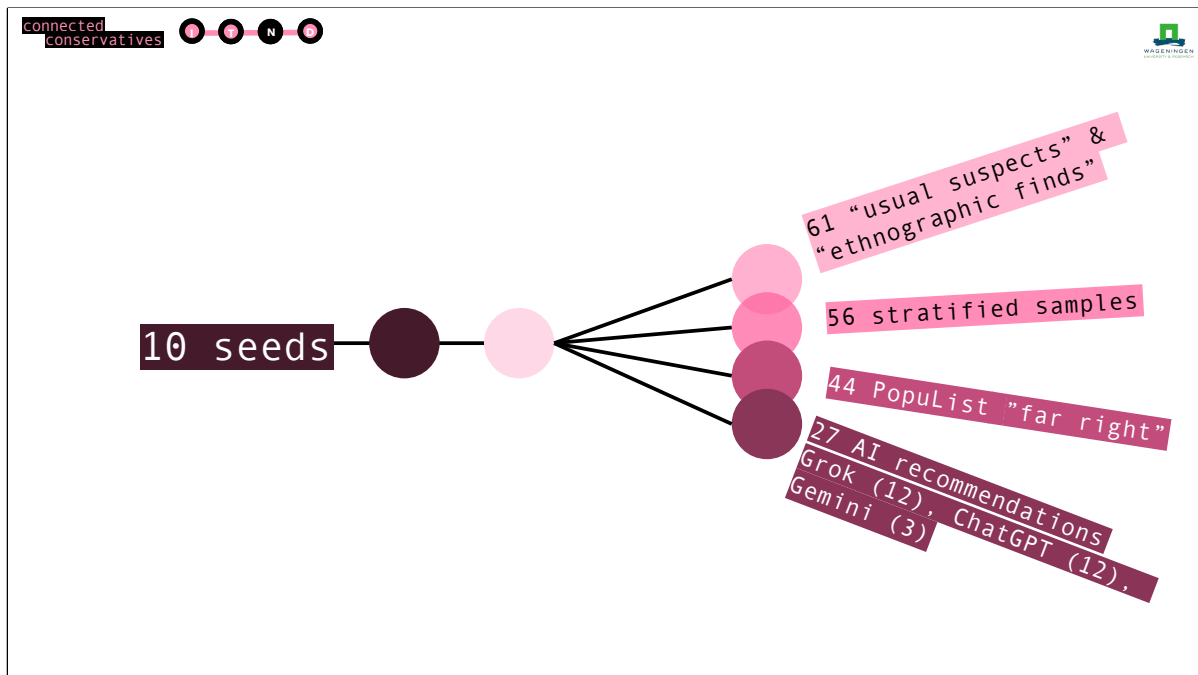
Last, some countries simply didn't appear, and we found out that X.com should not simply be assumed as a "far-right playground" in countries where X.com is a politically empty space



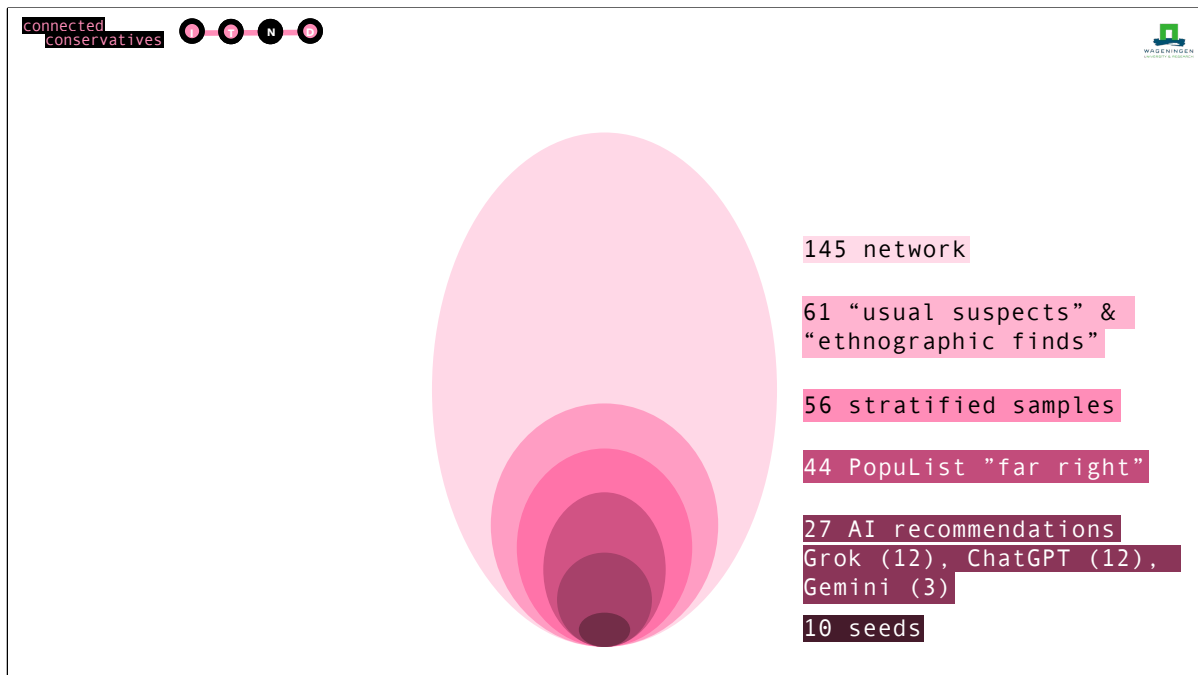
So what really happened:



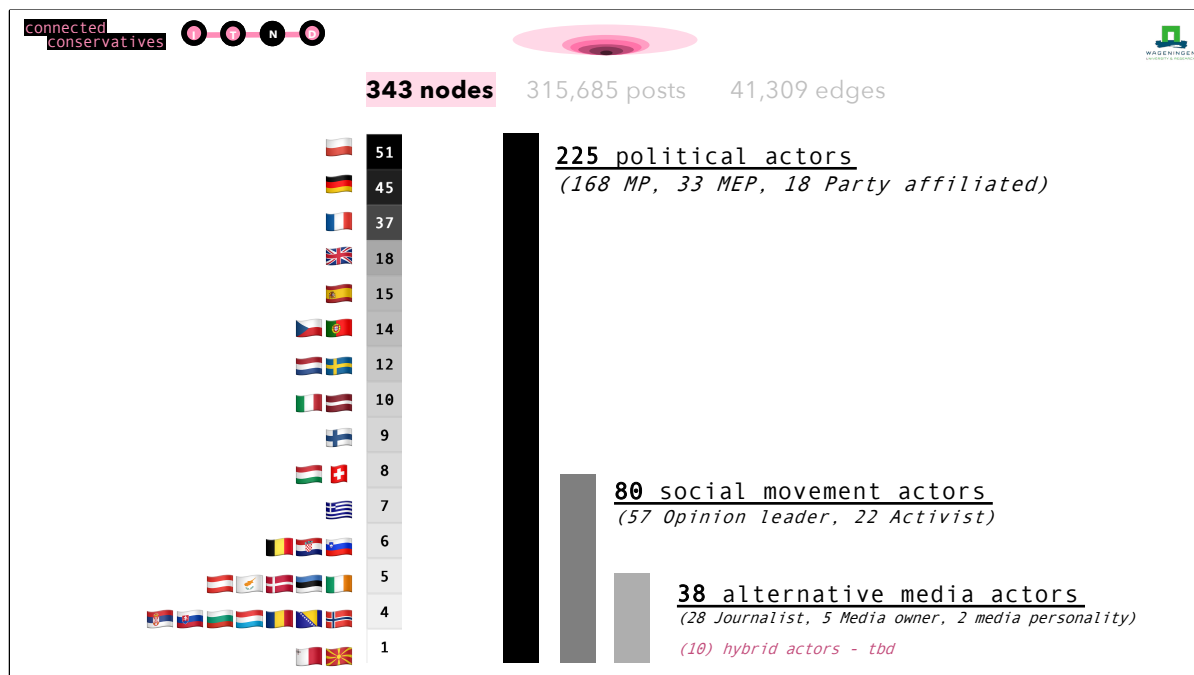
We recovered 145 actors as seeds through counting interactions within the network



And we expanded this seed-list with



To arrive at a distribution that looks like this vagina-esk figure



Zooming into the actors, I again stress the dominance of Poland.

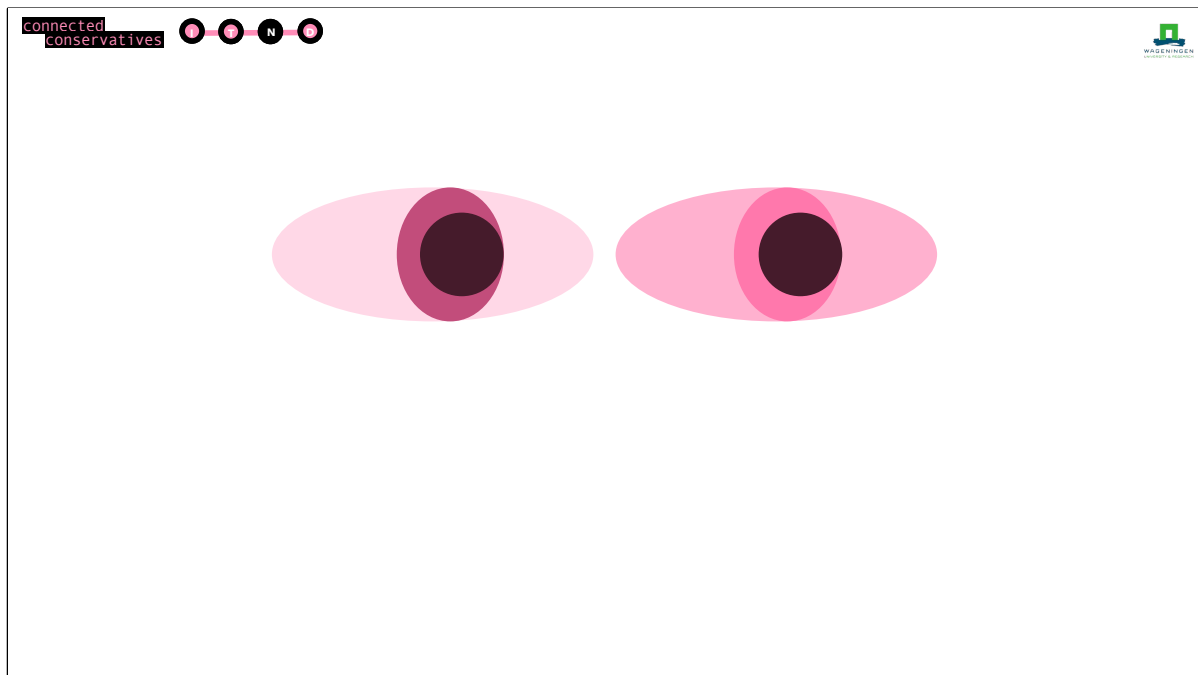
Out of these actors:

225 are political actors (MP MEP or party affiliated, like a spokesperson),

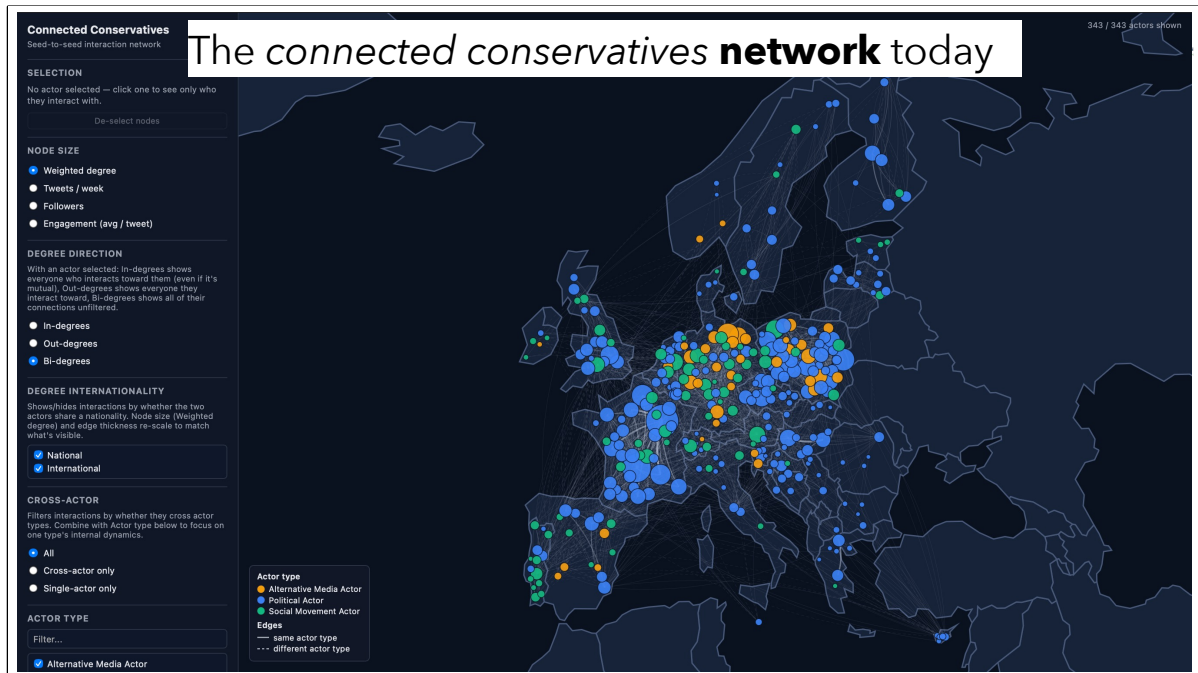
80 are social movement actors (opinion leaders/online commentators/independent journalists or activists)

38 are alternative media actors (journalists, media owners or media personalities)

And 10 fall within multiple categories - TBD

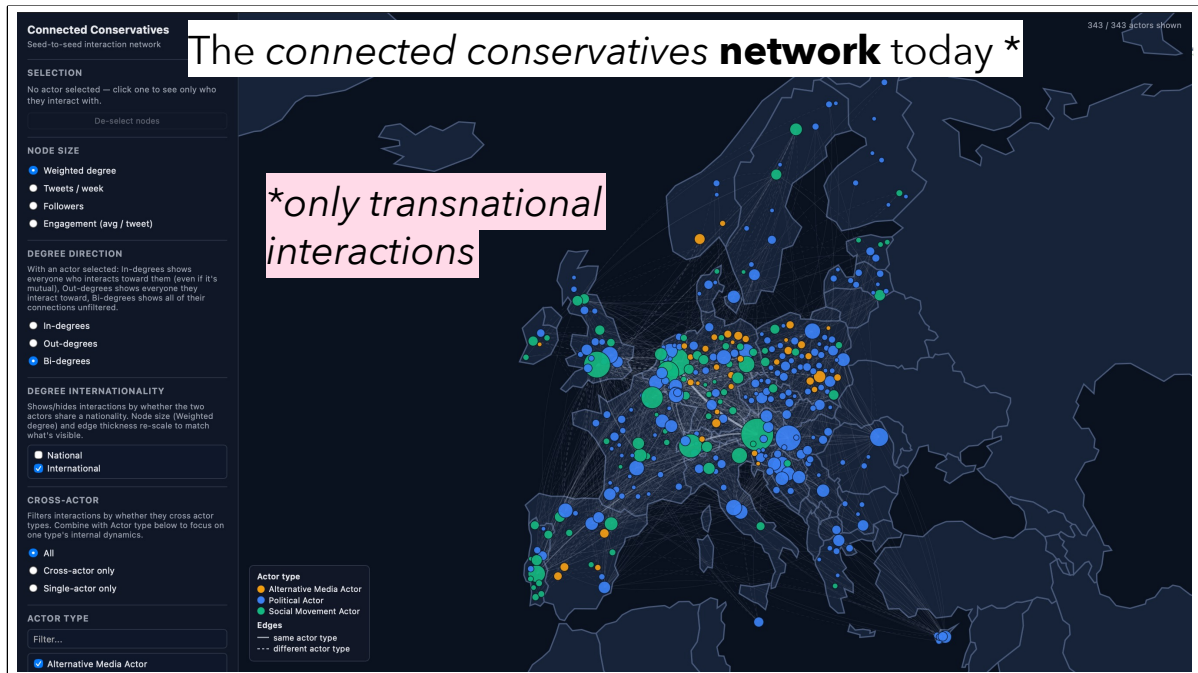


These results are quite fresh so let's first see how it looks before jumping to conclusions

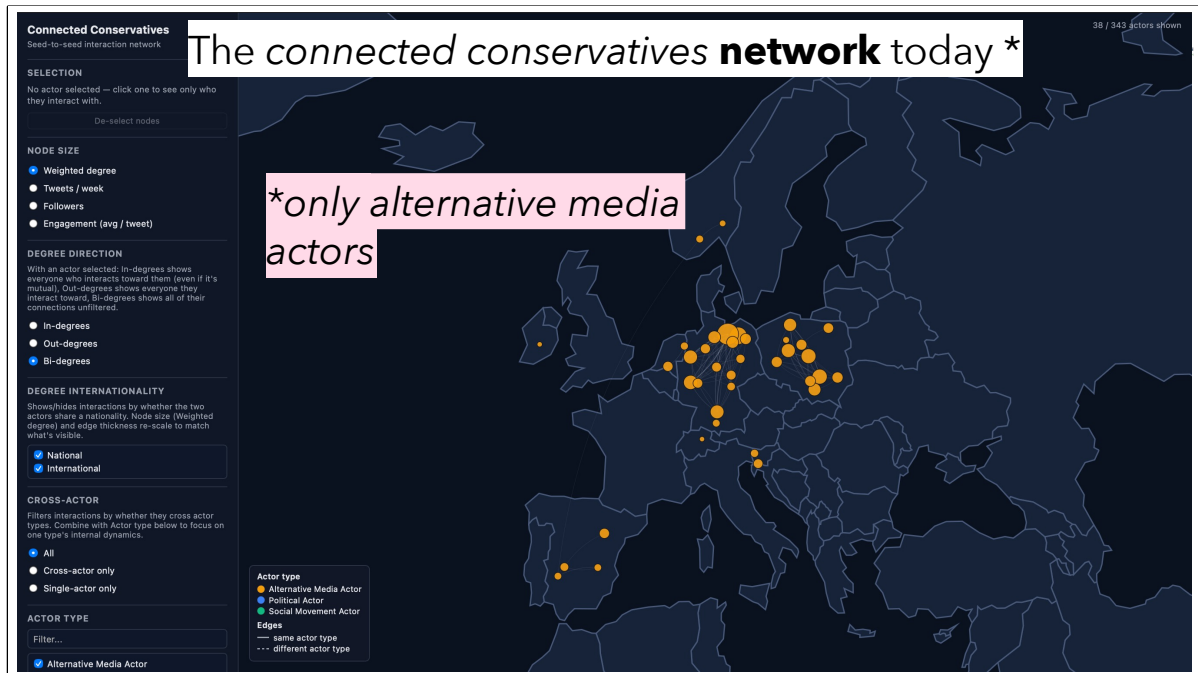


This is it. Bear in mind that the positioning of national nodes is random within the country, i.e. Jordan Bardella is not positioned in Paris even though he might have his office or luxurious penthouse apartment there. Also, note that the size of the nodes represents their centrality, i.e. how many interactions they have within our network.

We see, first, the domination by blue nodes, i.e. political actors. Now let's look at the hot topic of this conference: transnationalization



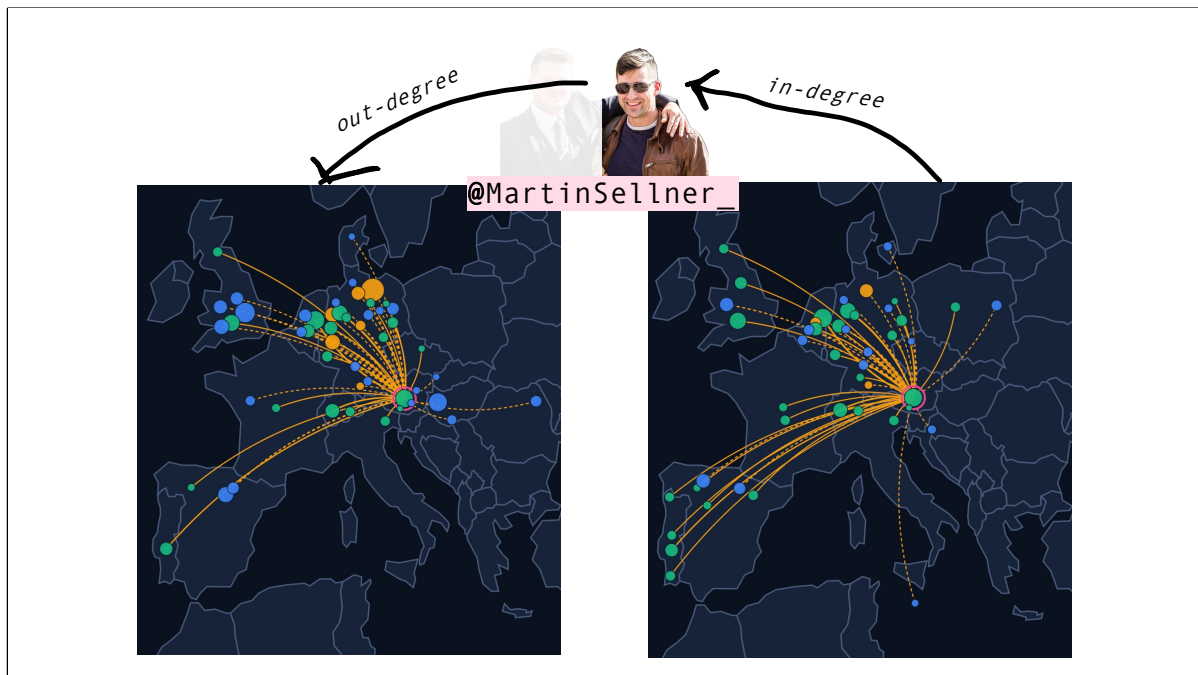
When we only look at transnational edges, i.e. between actors of different nationalities, we observe that not blue nodes, but green (social movement actors) dominate.



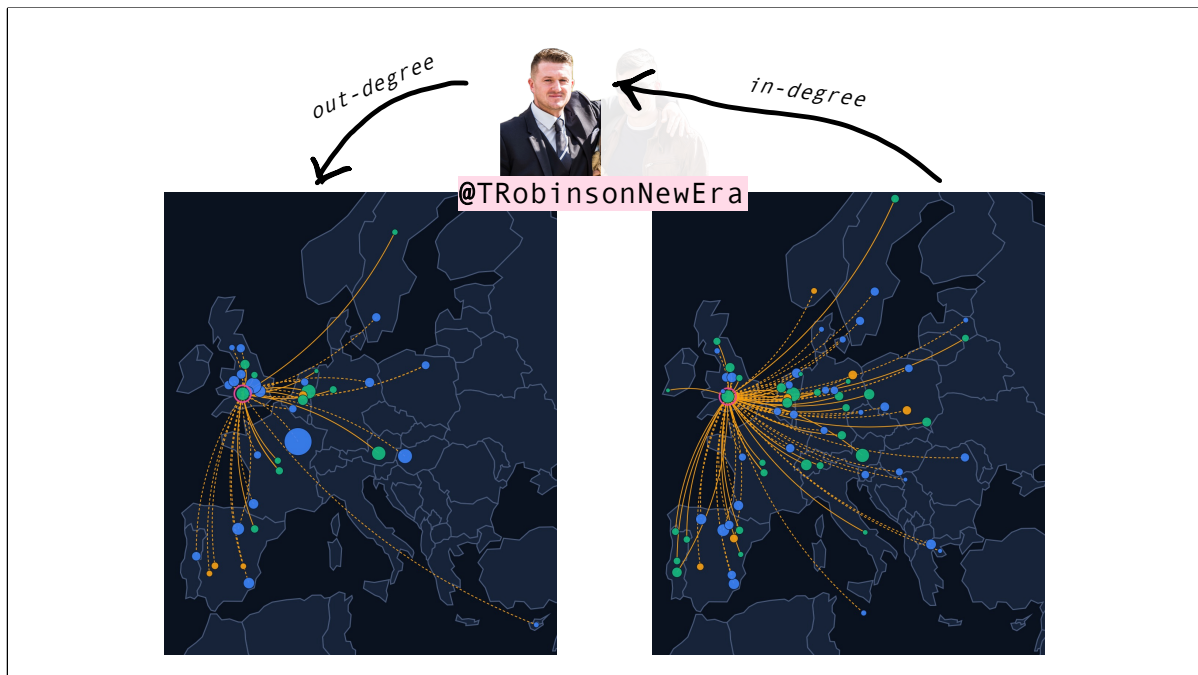
Another striking preliminary finding is that when we look at the alternative media actors, we observe a strong network in Germany and Poland, a little less big but still relevant in some other countries like Portugal and the Netherlands.



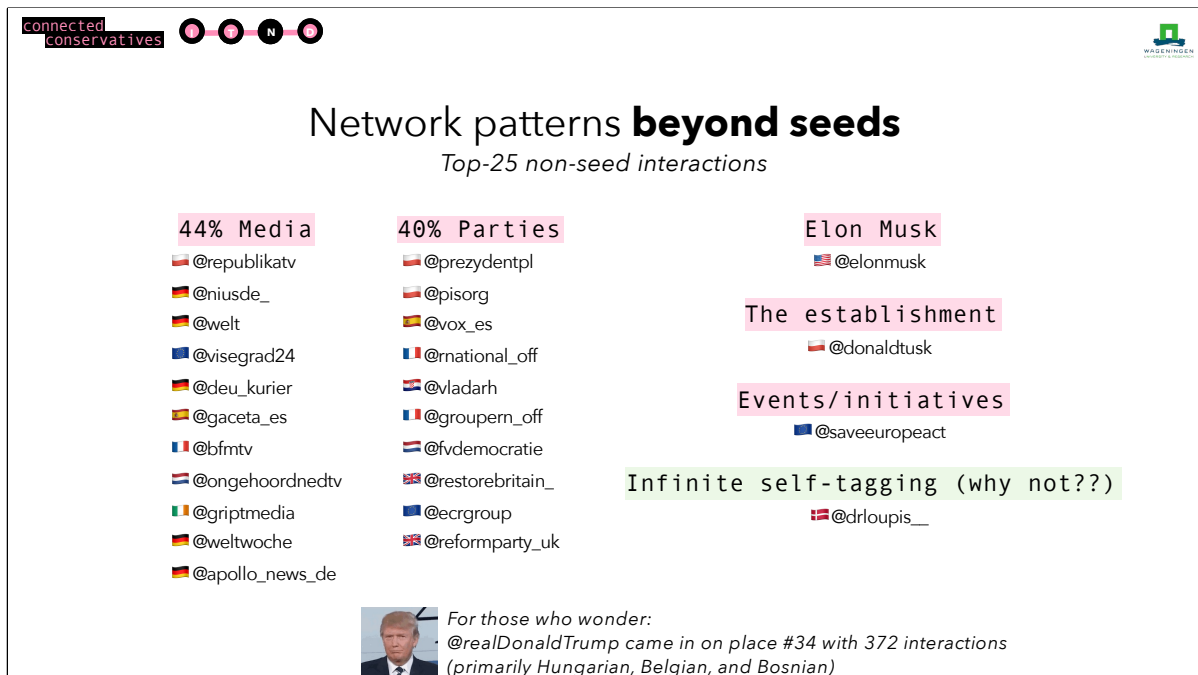
But to get a more tangible, relatable sense of this, lets inspect the dynamics around two of our ideal son-in-laws



For Martin Sellner, we see that in terms of interactions, the incoming and outgoing interactions within our network are at similar intensities. However, note that he is seeking contact with politicians much more than politicians do with him.



For Stephen Christopher Yaxley-Lennon, the tension between incoming and outgoing degrees look notably different and I think it is fair so say that we are talking about the “cool kid”, "enfant terrible", or "bad boy" of the class. His outgoing interactions are much lower compared to his incoming interactions. However, like for him as for the previous actor, we find that their outgoing degrees are directed at relatively more political actors compared to the share of actor types in their incoming interactions. All very interesting.



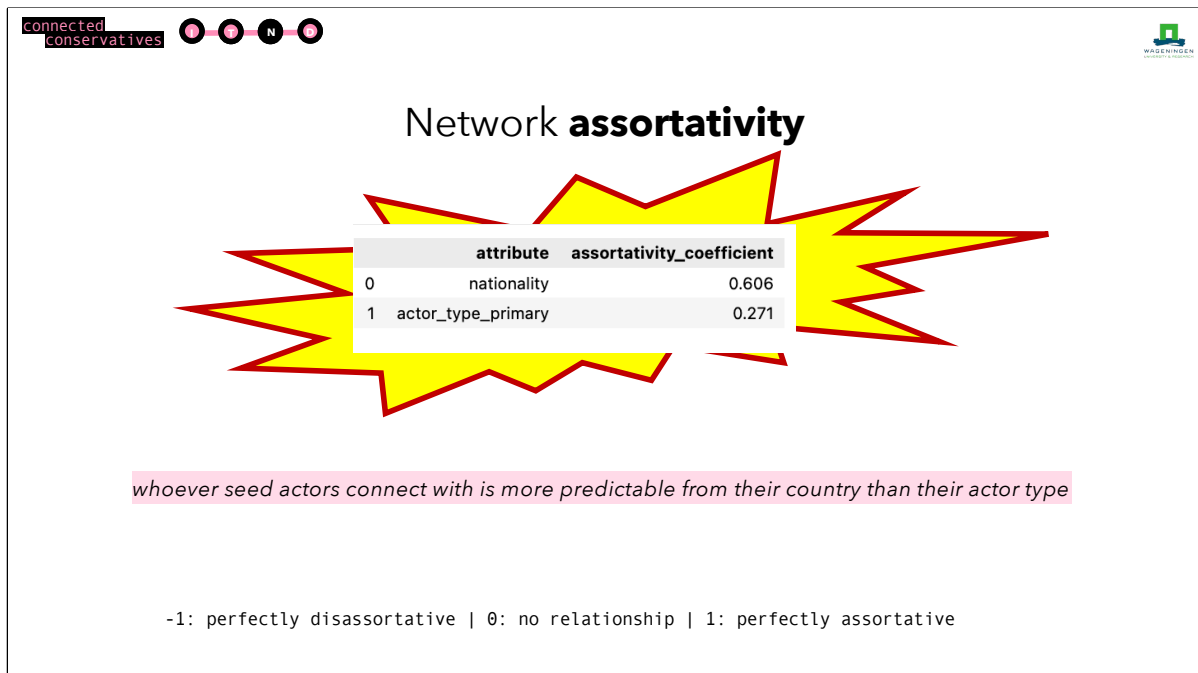
Just to be one step ahead of questions: yes, we looked outside the seed-to-seed interactions as well. And this is what we find in the top-25 of non-seed accounts. An overwhelming majority is interacting with the media, primarily media that is in their far-right-favor, or their official party accounts. See it as marketing.

In this top-25, Donald Tusk is the only mentioned establishment opponent, but this is due to data imbalance; further down we also find the Dutch prime minister, macron, merz, von der leyen, starmer, burham etc.

We also find events and initiatives represented in accounts such as the remigration summit and the fuckEuropeact



Although this project is in a draft stage, and because this is a political conference (and we are no more than infiltrators...), we will make sure you leave the room with a statistic...



And that is the – preliminary – network assortativity. This signals the category that best predicts interactions with similar actor types, corrected for chance. And here we find that nationality is the best predictor of seed-seed actor interactions.

De assortativiteitscoëfficiënt is in wezen een **correlatiecoëfficiënt**: hij vergelijkt het werkelijke aandeel same-group ties met het aandeel dat je *zou verwachten* als de ties willekeurig verdeeld waren, gegeven hoeveel ties elke groep sowieso heeft.

$$r = \frac{\sum_i e_{ii} - \sum_i a_i b_i}{1 - \sum_i a_i b_i}$$

$$r = 1 - \frac{\sum_i a_i b_i}{\sum_i e_{ii}}$$

Waarbij:

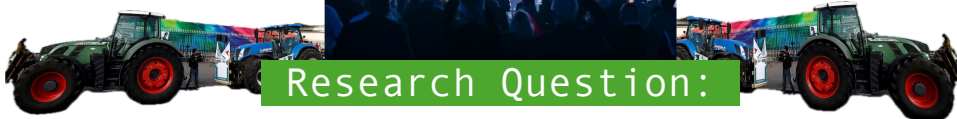
e_{ij} = fractie van alle edges die van groep i naar groep j lopen (genormaliseerd, sommeert tot 1)

e_{ii} = fractie edges *binnen* groep i — dit is je "werkelijke" interne fractie

$a_i = \sum_j e_{ij} = \sum_j a_i b_i$ = fractie edge-uiteinden die uit groep i komen (bij directed: de source-kant)

$b_i = \sum_j e_{ji} b_i = \sum_j e_{ji} =$ fractie edge-uiteinden die in groep i eindigen (target-kant)

$\sum_i a_i b_i / \sum_i a_i b_i =$ de **verwachte** fractie same-group ties **onder toeval**, gegeven hoe groot elke groep in het netwerk is



Research Question:

How do **European far right actors**
connect transnationally on X?

What we think we know now:

- *National connections > transnational connections*
- 👉 *Social movement actors are relatively more transnational*

What we're still to find out:

- 👤 *What type of connections exist between different actor types?*
- 🌐 *To what extent are these connections transnational?*



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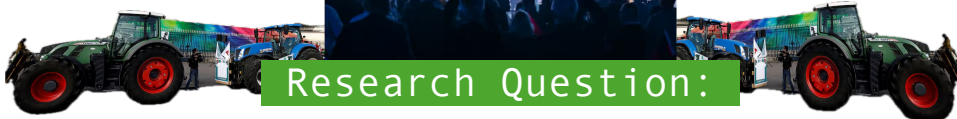
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THANK YOU!



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